

“Technology is shrinking the child's sense of community, lessening their sense of engagement with the wider society.” SANJAY SRIVASTAVA, *Social Anthropologist*

BHASKAR PAUL /www.indiatodayimages.com



PRANAV CHHABRIA 18, Mumbai Spends three hours on the computer every night

Pranav doesn't sleep before 2 a.m. every night and admits that he has become a nocturnal being since he started using the Internet three years ago. He is hooked to the Internet as he feels virtual socialising is much more fun. Pranav claims that the Internet helps him unwind after a hard day of school and tuition classes. His mother Amrita worries that Pranav's habits may make him unproductive at school but adds, "You cannot tell your children too much at that age because it shows you don't trust them. It's a Catch-22 situation".

92% children watch TV every day. **90%** of them have access to cellphones, which children in the 7-14 age group use at least once a week. **62%** homes own DVD players, up from 44% in 2008.



WWE

Offshoot of WWF, it's a junk entertainment corporation that earned \$525 million in revenue in 2008. Features matches between men clad in underwear who throw each other down, even as they spew profanities and mock fight for guest stars such as Torrie Wilson, declaring, "Torrie can only be mine". Its star Chris Benoit killed his wife and son in 2007 before committing suicide, blowing the lid off the drug scene among professional wrestlers. Airs on Ten Sports.

moving from presentational to representational role-playing, being empowered by technology, learning to be anything, from the manager of Manchester United to wrestler Shawn Michaels who urges his rivals to "suck it", they are also learning to walk on the wild side. Like Rahul (name changed), a 12-year-old boy in Standard VI of a leading public school in Delhi. He is the only sibling and lives in an upmarket three-bedroom apartment. On weekdays, he sits in front of his computer for five hours. On weekends, he spends 10 hours in his den online or

playing games. For a while, his parents did not worry, thinking he was occupied, especially as Rahul is good in studies. But now, they've found Rahul is on Orkut, connected to children all over the world, exchanging games, movies, comics and porn. Some of the games in his computer depict sex and violence, visually they look almost real. When they disconnected the Internet, Rahul got hysterical, threatening to run away, even refusing to go to school. When that didn't help, he stopped eating. That was enough for his parents to give in, but with software

that regulates his access to objectionable content.

It's a problem that is increasing. According to Cartoon Network's New Generations study of 7-14 year-olds and their parents, 49 per cent use the computer (whether at home or elsewhere). The percentage who surfed the Internet went up from 10 per cent in 2008 to 15 per cent in 2009. While 52 per cent who surfed the Internet listed online games as their favourite activity, 19 per cent said they had made a friend online whom they have never met in real life. Homes are becoming one-stop entertainment and communication hubs: according to the survey, 90 per cent of Indian homes in the cities have mobile phones, with children using it at least once a week, while 62 per cent of the homes own a DVD player, up from 44 per cent in 2008. And the big whopper: 92 per cent watch TV every day. Clearly, excessive screen time, of whatever kind, will have a damaging impact on the child's neuro-develop-



Internet Gaming

Searching for cheat sites which spring up around each video game sometimes leads to porn versions such as the site of the Naruto video game. Deep Throat Sakura, for instance, allows people to play the interactive Naruto free porn game and watch Sakura "giving a blow job to her partner".